The strategy was one of exposing the arrant hypocrisy of the colonial rulers. They had instigated a special trial procedure for twenty-five of the accused. Their trial before a regular magistrate was cut short and aborted while in full swing. Instead, they were put before a special tribunal. This act of desperation by the colonial authorities showed the rule of law in India to be a charade. And, this is what Bhagat Singh cleverly set out to expose. No wonder he saw his father's attempt to save him from the gallows as 'nothing short of treachery'. By intervening in this way, his father was inadvertently undoing the strategy that Bhagat Singh had so meticulously planned and worked for. This is why he told his father: 'Let me be candid. I feel as though I have been stabbed in the back.' Chastising his father, he struggled to contain his emotions, as he declared, 'I fear I might overlook the ordinary principles of etiquette, and my language may become a little bit harsh . . .'. And yet, managing to restrain himself just in time, he ends with the words, 'But, in your case, let me say that it has been a weakness – a weakness of the worst type.'[6] Coming from son to a father, these were harsh words, but Bhagat Singh was on the last leg of his journey, the journey to death. He could brook no interference, even if the interference was that of a tormented stricken father who was desperately helpless in the face of his eldest son's impending death.

The day before his hanging Bhagat Singh wrote a last letter to his 'Comrades' on 22 March 1931. Shiv Verma, who was himself detained in Ward Number 14, close to the cells of the condemned, slipped out a note to Bhagat Singh asking him if he would prefer to live. Bhagat Singh promptly wrote back,

> The desire to live is natural. It is in me also. I do not want to conceal it. But it is conditional. I don't want to live as a prisoner or under restrictions. My name has become a symbol of Indian Revolution. The ideal and sacrifices of the revolutionary party have elevated me to a height which I will never be able to rise if I live.

This vindicates Bhagat Singh's strategy of courting martyrdom which he had so carefully and painstakingly pursued right from the beginning. In fact, he was now able to also add that 'if I mount the gallows boldly and with a